

Flamingos

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Aves
ORDER	Phoenicopteriformes
FAMILIES	1 (Phoenicopteridae)
SPECIES	6

With their extremely long legs and neck, and colorful pink or red plumage, these tall wading birds are striking and instantly recognizable. They are found in the tropics and subtropics, usually in the shallows of

salt or brackish water or alkaline lakes, sometimes massed in vast flocks of up to one million birds. Despite their fragile appearance, flamingos occur in many parts of the world where few other animals can survive. They are frequently found in conditions of extreme salinity or alkalinity, and are remarkably tolerant of changes in temperature. Flamingos are specialized feeders, using their unusual downturned bill to filter tiny plants and animals from water.

Colonies

Flamingos are among the most social of birds, even performing their courtship displays in groups. Thousands of individuals open their wings or lift up and turn their heads in one vast, synchronized movement. These group displays seem to bring all the birds of the colony to the same readiness to mate, to ensure rapid, synchronized egg-laying as soon as conditions allow. Breeding colonies often form when the water level of a salt lake drops—the surface is suddenly covered with piles of raised mud, which form the flamingos' nests. The parents care for their young for the first week or two. Once a young flamingo is able to walk and swim, it joins a "creche" (see right).



GROUP DISPLAY
During courtship displays, flamingos may engage in "head-flagging," raising their neck and bill, and turning their head from side to side.



CRECHES
Young flamingos form large groups of up to 300,000 birds (here, lesser and greater flamingos). They are still fed by their parents but are guarded by an unrelated adult.

FLIGHT
Flying flamingos, with their thin neck and legs outstretched, are unmistakable. Large flocks often form long, curving lines. Their long wings and light body enable a relatively easy takeoff.



Anatomy

Flamingos have a slender body set on greatly elongated legs, which are longer in relation to body size than those of any other bird. The limbs are completely bare, allowing the birds to wade deep in highly saline or alkaline water without soiling their plumage. Flamingos have a long, flexible neck that, in the case of the larger species, is also remarkably thin. The head is small, and the bill has a characteristic downward bend. The way in which the upper and lower parts of the bill fit together, combined with the comblike plates on the bill's edges, make it a useful tool for sieving food from water (see right). The flamingo's unique pink or red coloration arises from a dye extracted from food such as algae and shrimps.



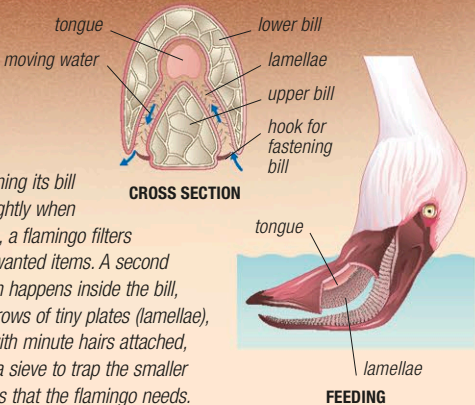
STANDING IN WATER
Flamingos (here, a greater flamingo) often stand on one leg for long periods, even when asleep, with the head laid on the body and the other leg tucked under the abdomen. This posture cuts heat loss through the legs and feet.

FEET
Compared with their long legs, the feet of flamingos are relatively small. The front 3 toes are webbed, and the back one is either tiny or missing. The webbing is useful for walking over mud or other soft surfaces.



Feeding

A flamingo usually feeds while wading in shallows, using its feet to stir up mud on the bottom. To feed, it puts its head to the surface (so that its bill is upside down and the tip points backward) and sweeps its head from side to side. By a rapid action of the tongue, it pumps water in and out of the slightly opened bill. Along the inside edge of the bill are rows of plates, known as lamellae, some of which have tiny hairs on them. The flamingo filters out food particles by sieving them past the lamellae and their hairs. The size of particles taken differs between species. Larger flamingos tend to feed on crustaceans, mollusks, and worms, and the smaller species on algae.



BILL
By opening its bill only slightly when feeding, a flamingo filters out unwanted items. A second filtration happens inside the bill, where rows of tiny plates (lamellae), often with minute hairs attached, act as a sieve to trap the smaller particles that the flamingo needs.



FEEDING ON ALGAE
Lesser flamingos (left) and other smaller species usually feed from the water surface. Larger flamingos immerse their heads completely to feed.